



Unmaking the Norm They Made

Free Trade, Protectionism, and the Contestation of the Post-War Trading Order

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Set question: *Analyse one existing global norm that will be challenged due to the changing world order.*

ABSTRACT

The norms of free trade established in the post-WWII order were designed to deliver not only economic growth and efficiency but also the cooperation and interdependence on which political stability among states was thought to rest. This essay argues that those norms are now under sustained challenge from rising protectionism, geopolitical tension, and an ascendant set of environmental and labour standards. Drawing on Finnemore and Sikkink's norm cycle model and Bloomfield's distinction between norm entrepreneurs and antipreneurs, it traces a reversal of roles in which the United States and the United Kingdom, the original architects of the free trade norm, have become the entrepreneurs of its protectionist successor, while China assumes the antipreneurial task of defending trade openness. A parallel cycle, catalysed from below by Pacific island law students and propelled by the International Court of Justice, illustrates how small actors increasingly exercise entrepreneurial agency in a changing global order.

Keywords: free trade • norm cycles • norm entrepreneurs • antipreneurs • protectionism • world order

1 Introduction

Free trade norms are the principles and standards that promote the exchange of goods and services across national borders with minimal restrictions. These norms are typically enshrined in free trade agreements, which aim to reduce tariffs, eliminate quotas, and harmonise regulations in order to facilitate cross-border trade. They were established in the post-WWII order not only to drive economic growth and efficiency, but also to entrench cooperation and interdependence between states in the hope of securing political stability among nations. The changing world order — characterised by shifts in global power dynamics, economic trends, and geopolitical relationships — is placing significant

pressure on these norms. This essay explores how three key factors, namely rising protectionism, geopolitical tension, and environmental and labour concerns, are challenging the post-WWII norm of free trade. To do so, it employs Finnemore and Sikkink's norm cycle model, alongside Bloomfield's concepts of norm entrepreneurs and antipreneurs, to analyse the emergence, adaptation, and contestation of norms.

2 Free Trade with Economic and Migration Protectionism?

In recent years there has been a noticeable shift toward protectionist policies, ranging from economic measures to immigration restrictions, each of which challenges the established norm of free trade. The status quo, championed by institutions such as the WTO, favoured open markets, reduced tariffs, and the free flow of goods and services as fundamental to global prosperity and peace.

Recent geopolitical tensions, however, have led to a breach of this norm. Firstly, the urgency for supply chain resilience has grown, largely out of fear of interdependence with volatile states. European reliance on Russian gas through Nord Stream, for instance, backfired at the onset of the Russo-Ukrainian War, resulting in an emergency decoupling from Russian energy supplies (Kardaś, 2023).

Secondly, there is increasing pressure for economic nationalism as a consequence of deindustrialisation in former industrial powers. The catalyst for this trend can be seen in the United States under the first Trump presidency, which won overwhelming support in the deindustrialised Rust Belt — not only across the American heartland, but even in large urban areas gutted by unemployment following deindustrialisation. The same pattern extends to the United Kingdom, where the economically deprived and deindustrialised regions of Northern England, known as the red wall, were among the most ardent supporters of Brexit. This norm change in the Anglosphere — the former champion of free markets and unrestricted trade — precipitated further norm change throughout Europe and East Asia. Europe was the most economically affected by Brexit, while East Asia was the most affected by Trump's reindustrialisation-oriented tariffs.

The norm entrepreneurs of economic nationalism — the United States and the United Kingdom — are, ironically, the very states that constructed and long maintained the status quo of free trade. Where they once defended that status quo against its challengers, domestic demand for economic nationalism has now made them the principal architects of its overturning. Rather than resisting increased economic protectionism, Europe and East Asia have embraced it, readily imposing tariffs on competing economies. China, long among the United States' largest trading partners and a historical advocate for freer trade, has imposed retaliatory tariffs of its own, indicating a willingness to follow the new norm entrepreneurs. Yet China simultaneously occupies the position of norm antipreneur, defending trade openness because its economy is oriented towards securing export markets. This defensive posture is equally clear in the formation of regional institutions aimed at lowering barriers to trade, such as BRICS and the Belt and Road Initiative. The BRI in particular has sought to connect Asia to Europe, essentially recreating the Silk Road in the modern day and replicating the openness and interconnectedness required to pursue trade across the diverse countries of the Eurasian landmass (Xi Jinping, 2014, p. 316; p.

320). China's drive for trade openness has not been ignored by the United States; it has been openly attacked by the second Trump administration. China's defence of trade openness thus makes it the most ardent norm antipreneur, while the United States' offensive position on protectionism makes it the norm entrepreneur.

Another indication of the American entrepreneurial role is the aggressive political posture adopted towards Canada, historically among the closest allies of the United States, following Trump's election. Trump does not view the US–Canada relationship as one of sentimentality, but as one that must deliver tangible economic benefits to the United States as the senior partner. This departs sharply from the policy of free trade both states have pursued since NAFTA came into force in 1994. Indeed, at the time NAFTA was concluded the United States had defeated the Soviet Union and secured both norm acceptance and norm internalisation for free trade and open markets (Chatzky, McBride and Sergie, 2023). The renegotiation of NAFTA after Trump's election, however, marked the start of a new norm cycle, once again led by the United States: norm emergence arose from domestic grievances over allegedly unfair trade arrangements with Canada, producing a norm cascade of retaliatory protectionism in Canada and Mexico that has gradually hardened into a new internationalised norm. This was not without pushback, as the Biden administration attempted to roll back the protectionist policies adopted under Trump — but to no avail, as the second Trump presidency doubled down on its protectionist vision. US–Canada relations thus serve as a useful indicator of the direction in which the United States, as norm entrepreneur, seeks to initiate a norm cycle.

3 Free Trade Norms versus Environmental and Labour Protection Norms

While the norm of free trade has been prevalent for sustaining cooperation and peace through interdependence, a competing norm has emerged around care for the environment and for labour practices. These concerns draw attention to the ways in which free trade may exacerbate environmental degradation and worker exploitation, particularly in countries with lax regulations and weak labour protections. The result has been growing demand for stricter standards within trade agreements themselves. The EU's trade agreement with Mercosur, agreed in principle in 2019, includes binding commitments to uphold the Paris Climate Agreement with the aim of curbing deforestation driven by agricultural exports (Trade and Economic Security, 2023). That the agreement has still not been ratified more than two decades after negotiations began is itself evidence of how sharply the balance between market openness and environmental protection is contested.

Similarly, the US–Mexico–Canada Agreement that replaced NAFTA incorporates enforceable labour provisions intended to improve working conditions in Mexico's manufacturing sector, addressing issues such as low wages and unsafe workplaces. These provisions are externally imposed: a developing state such as Mexico does not itself place strong emphasis on working conditions, but does so under economic pressure from the United States and Canada as its partners in the agreement.

Demand for this norm continues to strengthen, as reinforced by the ICJ's advisory opinion of 23 July 2025, which held unanimously that states bear obligations under international law to protect the climate system and that breach of those obligations carries

legal consequences (Diepeveen and Bosma, 2025). The opinion is formally non-binding, yet its authority as a statement of what international law requires is precisely what gives it normative force. Given that the proceedings originated with comparatively small political actors — law students at the University of the South Pacific, who formed Pacific Islands Students Fighting Climate Change and persuaded Vanuatu to carry the question to the General Assembly — it suggests that norms may increasingly face challenges from below, and that agency for smaller norm entrepreneurs is more readily exercised in a changing global order. Finnemore and Sikkink describe this stage of the norm cycle as norm emergence, in which a small actor is able to catalyse a new cycle as norm entrepreneur. Here the norm entrepreneurs are the students, while Vanuatu and then the Court propelled that emergence into a norm cascade.

4 Consequences and Considerations

Taken together, these challenges to free trade norms suggest a potential transformation of the global trading system. If protectionism and geopolitical tension persist, the world may see a retreat from open markets, with slower economic growth and increased international friction as likely consequences. Yet the same challenges could also drive the evolution of trade norms, with future agreements placing greater emphasis on sustainability and labour standards in order to address the shortcomings of traditional free trade models.

It is important to recognise that contestation is an inevitable part of the norm cycle. Norms necessarily enter a highly contested space in which they must compete with existing norms and with differing perceptions of interest. Norm entrepreneurs who promote new norms confront firmly embedded alternative norms and frames that present rival views of what is appropriate and of what serves whose interests (Finnemore and Sikkink, 1998, p. 897). Norm cycles are neither linear nor strictly chronological; they exist as general patterns and observations for a phenomenon that is seldom replicated in exact fashion. In the case of free trade there are ebbs and flows in when openness constitutes the norm at all. While it was the United States that initiated the free trade norm cycle in the post-WWII order, it is increasingly defiant of its own creation — no longer the guardian of that norm, but the entrepreneur of the protectionist norm now displacing it.

5 Conclusion

Free trade norms were created in the post-WWII order as a means of sustaining a cooperative and interdependent world. Despite this foundational role, they now face challenges from rising and competing agendas, namely protectionism on the one hand and environmental and labour concerns on the other. The future trajectory of these norms will depend on how states respond: whether by doubling down on protectionism, or by adapting trade frameworks to better balance economic openness with social and environmental priorities. This ongoing tension highlights the dynamic nature of global norms in an increasingly complex world order.

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